

SHELLS

written by

Kondwani Phiri

September/October 2023

Phone - 240 616 5951

E-mail - phiri@usc.edu or kondwanihp@outlook.com

INT. SCHOOL OFFICE - DAY

A group of three women is sitting lined up across from MRS.DANIELS (40s, Bigger, Lovable) office desk. In the middle is AMARA (17/18) on her left is MOM (40s) and to Amara's right is MAC (18/20).

AMARA is zoned out looking at a clock while Mrs. Daniels, Mom, and Mac have just finished catching up and are waiting for Amara to say something.

Amara is still zoned out. Mrs. Daniels snaps sarcastically at Amara.

MRS. DANIELS

Hey! Amara! You there! Let's get started today!

Amara jolts in her seat before bringing her mind back to Mrs. Daniels.

AMARA

My bad, my bad. Yeah, let's get to it.

MRS. DANIELS

So, you, your mom, and your sister are all here today because you have finally decided to be a candidate for South Orenia High's full-ride scholars program.

AMARA

Yes.

Amara says nothing else.

Mrs. Daniels is forced to pick up the conversation.

MRS. DANIELS

Amara, as you know, I've been asking you to apply for this program for years at this point. I've always told you how smart and how much potential I think you have. Why do you wait until 1 week until the sponsor deadline to meet to me? And with no resume either? I'm here to support you, but what has been going on? I've barely seen you at school recently either?

Amara takes a deep breath.

AMARA

There's been a lot. A lot, but I
think I really started considering
it after one of many fights with my
(air quotes)
beloved sister, Mac.

Mac snickers.

FADE TO:

INT. FAMILY HOME, BEDROOM - DAY, (FLASHBACK)

Mac bursts open the door into Amara's room and immediately
gets in her face holding a dirty sock to Amara's face.

Amara pushes the sock out of the way and yells at Mac.

AMARA

Shut the fuck up! I'm sick and
tired of this shit everyday.

MAC

How the fuck are you mad when
you're the one always leaving dirty
shit in my room!

Amara gets up and shoves Mac out of the way to leave the
room. Mac gets up and runs near the door to continue the
dispute and block Amara's way.

Before they can keep going, the door flies open, and Mom
enters with fury, her victim being Amara.

MOM

18 and 20 years old! Too grown to
be arguing in my damn house like a
damn UFC press conference! Mac at
least has a 4.0 at Berkeley, but
you Amara, you, failing a class!
Skipping school! I expect better
from you, I mean you supposed to
be--

ELIA (20s, tall) comes into the bedroom and gently lifts Mom
away from Amara.

ELIA

Mom, relax, lemme talk to her.

Mom sighs and puts her hands up in defeat.

MOM
Fine, you take her.

Elia picks her up off the wall and walks her into her room.

INT. BEDROOM, FAMILY HOME - DAY, (FLASHBACK)

Amara and Elia sit on Elia's bed.

AMARA
Fuck! Why is she always on my case?
And fuck Mac, too always trying to
do something to set me off.

Elia just looks at her. Without judgment, as if to let Amara see her reflection in Elia's eyes. Amara takes a breath.

ELIA
You good now, Ronda Rousey?

AMARA
(laughing)
Yes, I'm fine.

ELIA
You need to chill a little. She loves you, Mom, even if it's in ways she can't explain. That's why she's so hard on you, she expects more, and that's why she's always testing you with that damn question. It's corny and stupid, but it's important, and you need to be able to answer at some point.

Amara sighs.

AMARA
If you ask that damn question again...
(grunts)

Elia hugs Amara tightly and does a fake deep voice.

ELIA
(mockingly)
At some point when I ask you this question. You're going to have to answer me.

AMARA
Ughhh.

ELIA

We've been here a million times
before.
For the millionth time, how are YOU
going to define yourself?
(beat.)
Now there's something that you
ain't gotta worry about Mac about.

CUT BACK TO:

INT. SCHOOL OFFICE - DAY (PRESENT)

AMARA

It's a question she would always
ask me whenever I would get in
trouble or when Mac and I would
fight. But it was always Elia who
would say things in a way that put
them in perspective. I'm not sure
if it was her being older or the
fact that mom was always comparing
me to Mac who--

MOM

--Let's not get ahead of ourselves
now, Miss.

Amara sighs in frustration. Mrs. Daniels looks at Amara with
a smile. Observant.

MRS. DANIELS

Well, it seems this is something
you've been thinking about for a
while. What was it that finally
pushed you?

AMARA

That's the main thing I wanted to
get to. But it's been tough for me
to talk about. It's been a while
since it happened, but I still
think about it every single day.

MRS. DANIELS

Is it the reason why Elia isn't
here with us today?

Amara pauses quietly for a moment. Mrs. Daniels clutches
Amara's hand on the desk.

MRS. DANIELS (CONT'D)
Only tell me if you feel
comfortable, darling.

Amara takes another deep breath and opens her mouth. Before a word gets out, we...

FADE TO:

EXT. GANG MEMBERS HOME - NIGHT

Elia and Amara are outside on the porch of a rough home somewhere in LA. There's a little gang kickback going on, Elia's ready to have a great time, and Amara is uncomfortable.

ELIA
You look a little nervous for
somebody who's been begging me to
come out for months now. Relax.
They're good people.

Amara hesitates nervously.

AMARA
Yeah, yeah, yeah you got it.

Elia pulls Amara in playfully. And whispers in her ear as they walk towards doorbell. Elia rings it.

ELIA
But... There will be some business
being done, but we won't be
involved, you just relax and have
fun and get to know everybody. If
anything goes south, I'll be there,
just listen to me. It's a chill
night, though. So just... relax.

AMARA
(exhales)
Fine. Fine. Whatever.

ELIA
Also, this is a one-time thing.
Whatever mom has been hounding you
about, she's kinda right, you gotta
be able to answer that q before you
wanna follow me round all day.

A random opens the door.

Amara sighs. Elia laughs.

SUPER: 1 hour later.

Amara and Elia are sitting in a group of very happy gangbangers laughing and telling stories while holding sticks and marshmallows. Amara looks much more comfortable, and Elia looks at her proudly.

JORDAN (20s) is standing in the center of the group, telling a story.

JORDAN

And then boom! I hit that nigga.
Sqaure inna jaw.

Amara and Elia and the group all crack up laughing.

AMARA

(laughing)

I just don't get it though Jordan,
how you gon' go from an honors
student to a *Chemist*

JORDAN

(joking tone)

Well, you see Amara. It's a kinda
reverse success process, you start
all the way at the top of your
class and work your way down to
local drug dealer. From what Elia
tells me though you supposed to be
the top of your class though? So
why you laughing?

Amara sucks her teeth and looks away.

ELIA

Best of the best. When she tries.

JORDAN

See that's the thing, it's just a
matter of you versus what you gonna
allow yourself to do.

Beat.

ELIA

Come on Jordan. No need to be such
an ass about it though. She gets
enough of this at home.

JORDAN

You right, my bad. It's just I've
seen too many kids lose they lives
over dumb--

BANG!

CUT TO:

INT. SCHOOL OFFICE - DAY (PRESENT)

Amara begins to struggle to breathe and starts hyperventilating. Mac and Mom both put their hands on Amara giving her sometime to regain her strength.

Amara breathes a little before speaking again. Mrs. Daniels is patient with her.

AMARA

And that was it. As soon as the gunshot sounded, I passed out from fear. The last thing I remember is waking up in the hospital and being told that my older sister is dead.

A moment of painful silence. A moment to reflect on those lost and what's next to come. Amara stares at a clock in the room for a little before Mrs. Daniels restores time to the room.

MRS. DANIELS

I see.

Mrs. Daniels reaches out to Amara to hold her hands tightly across the table.

MRS. DANIELS (CONT'D)

I'm so proud of you for finally coming here today Amara. Even with everything that you're going through. I'm beyond proud of you.

Amara takes another deep breath before gathering her words together.

AMARA

Thank you. I hope through this I can find a few answers though.

Amara chuckles.

MAC

Well let's get to searching then.